My Birthright
2026, An A5 text-only editorial publication

Context
Some essays stay with you because they touch on experiences you recognise, even if they aren't entirely your own. *My Birthright* by Karan Mahajan explores belonging, cultural identity and the ways our roots continue to shape us, even when we move away from home. I connected with its reflections on memory, family and the feeling of existing between different places and cultures. The essay became an opportunity to explore how typography, layout and the physical experience of reading can carry a story without the support of images.

My role
Essay selection, editorial research, typographic exploration, layout and book production.

Process
The brief called for a text-only book, where every design decision had to come from the words themselves. I explored typefaces, hierarchy, grids, spacing and pacing to understand how the reader would move through the essay. Without images, typography became the main visual language, with each spread designed to support the rhythm and tone of the writing.

Outcome
An A5 printed mini book featuring the complete essay, designed entirely through typography and layout. The project helped me understand how editorial design can shape the reading experience and how much visual expression can come from text alone.


My
Birthright
Karan Mahajan

Was I writing about there because I couldn't accept my life here?

From the start, my immigration to the U.S. was infused with denial. I wasn't even properly speaking an immigrant. When I arrived, after all, I was already a citizen.

This was a quirk of personal history. My father had emigrated from India to the U.S. in 1965—soon after the passage of Lyndon Johnson's 1965 Immigration Act—for a master's degree. In 1973, my mother joined him, and for thirteen years, they lived together in Chicago, Illinois; Nashua, New Hampshire; and Stamford, Connecticut.

Coming back to America fifteen years after I had left. It was more of a beginning than a return. I possessed no memories of my earlier time here, and, like many new immigrants, I struggled to take care of myself after a life cosseted by family. All the same, I had a familiarity with American culture that my parents had handed down to me. I also held strong to my Indian roots. My parents, for example, had never developed American accents. Nor did I. I had started writing poetry as a highschool student in Delhi, and now, in creative-writing classes, I attempted stories set in my home town. Writing about India from the command center of Silicon Valley was, at least initially, an expression of cultural confidence. I knew who I was and where I was from. Unlike some of my Asian American peers, who had been raised within a white superstructure, I did not write about white people by default. At the same time, as I mentally summoned India in my dorm room, with the golden hues of California outside my window, I was filled with doubt. How much did I really know about the place where I had grown up? My childhood had been cloistered, and I'd glimpsed just a sliver of the Indian experience; around me lay a great area of darkness to be explored. If I wanted to be a real Indian writer—like Arundhati Roy or R. K. Narayan—I would have to immerse myself in the Indian reality, become one with my nation. And so, by a strange act of mental jujitsu—declaring myself an "Indian writer" in the West—I forced upon myself a second, figurative passport: a passport to India, where I planned now to return after completing my studies in economics and English, dedicating myself to painting an accurate picture of the country that India was becoming, my writing unshadowed by the corrupting eyes of the West.

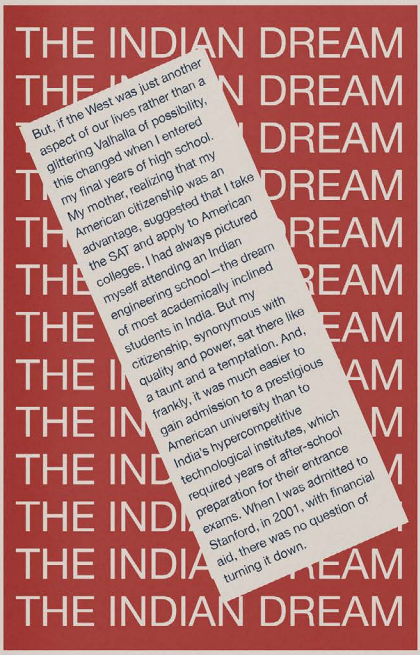
But there was already an irony within this declaration, because it was America—through its permissive creative-writing classes, which my engineer friends slogging away in India would have considered a joke—that had allowed me to declare myself a writer, away also from the judgment of my bourgeois Punjabi milieu, in which literary life was looked down upon as an effete, unremunerative curiosity. I told myself that I would return to India when I published my first novel. After graduating, I accepted a low-pay, low-stress publishing job, in San Francisco, and worked on my first novel in the evenings and on weekends. The novel was a comedy about an urban-planning minister in Delhi who is only attracted to his wife when she's pregnant and so keeps fathering child after child. Like so many works in which a writer discovers his voice, its energy came from the gentle domestic dramas of R. K. Narayan on one hand, and the transgressive, bawdy approach of Philip Roth on the other, as well as the hyper-sexed world of American colleges, where sex was discussed in such a puerile fashion that the quasi-official chant of my freshman dorm had been "Who are we? Brahmin! What do we want? Sex!" The book, which I titled "Family Planning," emerged quickly, a product of excitement and desperation.

And, examining myself through Indian eyes, I judged myself. I was ashamed of what I wanted to do. It didn't seem serious. It didn't seem right for an academically gifted Indian boy whom everyone expected to study computer science and to work at Microsoft or Goldman Sachs.

In 1986, when I was two and my younger brother was just six months old, they repatriated to India, with us in tow. My brother and I were, in a sense, "anchor babies," though, in another way, we were the reverse: our arrival in my parents' marriage quickened their realization that they didn't want their kids to grow up in the States. We tore our parents' anchors from America even as we gained birthright citizenship.

From then on, my brother and I grew up in upper-middle-class Delhi, surrounded by relatives. We attended a local school—not an American or British educational outpost—and our parents never seriously considered returning to the U.S., even though, at the time, material conditions in India were, in many ways, a generation behind the place they'd left. From a world of abundant brands and wondrous gadgets, we had come to a city with days striped by power outages. There were two national channels on TV and only a handful of brands of sluggish cars. Bureaucratic delays were rampant. Yet my mother, especially, felt she had made the right decision, choosing her culture over America's capitalist escalator to nowhere. (My father, aggravated by the inefficient business culture of nineteen-eighties India, was more ambivalent.)

All the same, my brother and I remained connected to America. There was our American citizenship—India, thanks to a post-colonial suspicion of divided loyalties, does not allow dual citizenship—but also the matter of our parents. Their years in the U.S. had changed them. Unlike many of their peers, they were dead set against a culture of casual graft. Courting terminal uncoolness, they routinely scolded fellow-Indians for their habit of throwing trash and wrappers in the street. Religious rituals were rarely observed in our home. My parents spoke English confidently and had an easy traffic with the West and Westerners. My father, an engineer, still consulted for companies that he had worked with previously in the U.S. and Europe. During my childhood, he often travelled abroad, bringing back toys and springing open his hard-shell American Tourister suitcase the minute he arrived.



Link to the full publication :
https://heyzine.com/flip-book/694065bc8c.html